What Lowi Predicted: Redistributive Legislation and the Committee Processing Penalty in the Korean National Assembly

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Abstract

Does the substantive content of legislation predict its fate at the committee stage? Theodore Lowi's foundational typology predicts that redistributive policies generate organized opposition on both sides, creating greater political friction than distributive policies. Despite six decades of theoretical development, this prediction has never been tested at the committee processing stage, where the vast majority of legislation in modern democracies succeeds or fails. I classify 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly's 20th and 21st terms (2016-2024) by policy type and trace their committee processing outcomes. Redistributive legislation faces a 9.3 percentage-point committee processing penalty after controlling for arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, bill seriousness, and committee fixed effects. This penalty operates within committees and within individual sponsors' portfolios, ruling out compositional explanations. The penalty nearly triples under divided government. These findings suggest that legislative effectiveness is conditioned not only by legislator attributes but also by policy type - a dimension the existing literature has overlooked.

1. Introduction

Redistributive policies create identifiable winners and identifiable losers. A minimum wage increase benefits low-wage workers and costs their employers. A mandatory childcare contribution benefits working parents and costs firms. A welfare expansion benefits recipients and costs taxpayers. Lowi (1964) argued that this zero-sum character gives redistributive policy a distinctive political dynamic: both sides mobilize, conflict is intense, and legislative consensus is difficult to achieve. Distributive policies, by contrast, create beneficiaries without generating organized opposition - a targeted subsidy or tax break rewards a constituency while the costs are diffuse and imperceptible. The political path for distributive legislation is correspondingly smoother.

This prediction is among the most widely taught in political science, yet there exists, to our knowledge, no empirical test of it at the committee processing stage - the institutional site where the overwhelming majority of legislation succeeds or fails. In the Korean National Assembly (KNA), 80% of failed bills die after being placed on a standing committee's agenda but before receiving any committee decision (Analyst, Round 1). In the United States Congress, the vast majority of proposals similarly "languish in this vital agenda-setting stage" (Krutz 2005, 313). If Lowi's prediction holds, redistributive bills should be disproportionately represented among the dead - not because committees deliberately discriminate against them, but because the organized opposition they generate makes the consensus required for committee action structurally harder to achieve.

This paper tests that prediction using 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly's 20th (2016-2020) and 21st (2020-2024) terms. I classify bills by policy domain and Lowi type using keyword-based text analysis of bill propose-reason texts, then estimate logistic regression models of committee processing outcomes with committee fixed effects, arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, and bill seriousness controls. Three findings emerge.

First, legislation targeting workers, welfare recipients, and care populations faces a 9.3 percentage-point penalty in the probability of receiving any committee decision, controlling for observable confounds. This penalty varies across committees (from 6.8 to 16.8 percentage points) but is negative in every committee examined. Second, the penalty operates within individual legislators' portfolios: among 327 legislators who introduced at least five bills in each category, the same legislator's redistributive bills fare 11.9 percentage points worse than the same legislator's non-redistributive bills. This within-sponsor comparison rules out the possibility that the penalty merely reflects compositional differences between the types of legislators who sponsor different kinds of bills. Third, the penalty interacts powerfully with political regime: under unified government, the processing disadvantage is a modest 7.0 percentage points, but under divided government it expands to 18.4 percentage points.

These results connect to and extend three literatures. I provide the first committee-level test of Lowi's (1964) redistributive-distributive distinction, showing that the typology predicts processing outcomes with striking precision: redistributive labor bills face a 15.7 percentage-point penalty relative to distributive labor bills, while care and welfare bills - where opposition is diffuse rather than organized - show no Lowi gradient at all. This pattern is consistent with a refinement linking Lowi to Olson (1965): the redistributive penalty materializes only when the losing side can organize to oppose. I also extend Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer's (2016) analysis of content-classified bill fates, which documented that women's issues bills in the U.S. Congress pass at half the rate of other legislation but did not decompose the penalty into committee-stage versus floor-stage components. The KNA data isolate the committee decision rate as the primary bottleneck. Finally, I engage the legislative effectiveness literature (Volden and Wiseman 2014), which has measured effectiveness as an attribute of legislators. The within-sponsor finding suggests that effectiveness is also conditioned by what the legislator is trying to do: the same legislator achieves systematically different committee processing rates depending on the policy type of the legislation.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the theoretical foundations and derives expectations. Section 3 describes the KNA data, the classification procedure, and the empirical strategy. Section 4 presents the main results and robustness checks. Section 5 discusses the findings in light of the theoretical framework and addresses limitations. Section 6 concludes.

2. Literature and Theory

Lowi's Typology and Its Untested Committee-Level Implication

Lowi (1964) argued that the character of a policy determines the character of the politics surrounding it. Distributive policies - targeted benefits to specific constituencies, financed from the general treasury - generate political support from beneficiaries without mobilizing organized opposition. Redistributive policies - transfers from identifiable losers to identifiable winners - generate conflict between both sides, as organized interests on the losing end mobilize to block or weaken the proposal. Regulatory policies fall between these poles. Wilson (1980) formalized this intuition into a two-by-two matrix of concentrated

versus diffuse benefits and costs, which Kim (2019) has applied to the Korean National Assembly to show that policy type predicts which bills receive public hearings. Despite this theoretical development, no study has tested whether Lowi's typology predicts committee processing outcomes - the stage at which most legislation is decided.

The prediction is straightforward. In a committee with limited processing bandwidth, redistributive bills require more deliberation time because committee members face cross-pressured constituents. A labor committee considering a minimum wage increase must weigh the demands of worker organizations against employer associations; a welfare committee considering a benefits expansion must balance recipient advocacy groups against fiscal conservatives. Distributive bills - a targeted subsidy for small businesses, a tax credit for a specific industry - face no comparable organized opposition. Committees operating under time constraints should therefore process distributive bills more efficiently, yielding higher decision rates for distributive legislation even absent any deliberate committee bias.

Legislative Winnowing and Committee Capacity

Krutz (2005) provides the most directly relevant empirical framework. Studying U.S. congressional committees, Krutz shows that the "winnowing" process - by which committees determine the small percentage of bills that receive attention - is structured by political cues including party affiliation and sponsor seniority. Committees cannot process every bill and instead rely on heuristic signals to triage the queue. Lewallen (2020) extends this analysis, arguing that as party leaders gained agenda control, committees shifted resources from lawmaking to oversight, further constraining the bandwidth available for bill processing.

Applied to the KNA, the winnowing framework generates a baseline prediction: committee processing should be driven by capacity constraints and arrival timing rather than by bill content. Prior analysis of KNA data supports this prediction in the aggregate: bills introduced earlier in the Assembly term receive decisions at substantially higher rates (42.7% in Year 1 versus 27.5% in Year 4), and neither sponsor party nor cosponsor count predicts committee action (Analyst, Rounds 2-3). The question this paper asks is whether the winnowing process, while not overtly partisan, is nonetheless content-sensitive - producing systematically different processing rates for redistributive versus distributive legislation.

Content-Classified Bill Fates

Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) provide the closest precedent for this paper's empirical strategy. They classify U.S. House bills by content - identifying "women's issues" as bills sponsored at elevated rates by women members - and track their legislative fates. Their headline finding: women's issues bills pass at a 2% rate compared to 4% for all bills. This content-classified fate analysis establishes that legislation on certain topics faces systematically worse outcomes, but Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer do not decompose the penalty into committee-stage versus floor-stage components. The present paper extends their approach with three innovations: (1) committee-level decomposition of the content penalty, (2) interaction with political regime (unified versus divided government), and (3) a within-sponsor identification strategy that controls for unobserved legislator characteristics.

The broader Legislative Effectiveness Score (LES) framework developed by Volden and Wiseman (2014) and extended to U.S. state legislatures by Bucchianeri, Volden, and Wiseman (2024) measures effectiveness as a legislator-level attribute. The LES does not distinguish between a legislator who advances five distributive bills and one who advances five redistributive bills - both score equally. If the

policy type of legislation independently predicts processing outcomes, as I argue, then effectiveness is conditioned by both legislator attributes and bill content. This is the theoretical contribution the Lowi-Volden synthesis provides.

Korean Legislative Studies

The Korean literature on bill passage has focused extensively on sponsor-level determinants. Kim and Lee (2023) show that a bill sponsor's position on the reviewing subcommittee predicts passage, establishing that institutional access matters. Yoon and Shin (2023) find that a sponsor's centrality in the cosponsorship network predicts bill success. An, Park, and Lee (2025) use logistic regression and SHAP analysis to identify which sponsor characteristics predict passage in the 20th and 21st Assemblies. These studies ask "what kind of legislator succeeds?" but not "what kind of legislation succeeds?" The present paper fills this gap by testing whether policy content independently predicts committee processing outcomes, controlling for sponsor characteristics.

Kang and Park (2025) document "waffling" in the KNA - legislators sponsoring bills they later vote against - confirming that bill introduction and genuine legislative intent are not equivalent. This raises a critical identification concern: if redistributive bills attract more position-taking sponsors, the processing penalty could reflect bill-pool quality rather than content-based processing differences. I address this concern directly through within-sponsor comparisons and seriousness-proxy stratification.

Expectations

Drawing on Lowi's typology and the winnowing framework, I derive two expectations:

H1. *Redistributive legislation faces lower committee processing rates than distributive legislation, controlling for arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, and committee fixed effects.*

H2. *The redistributive processing penalty is larger in policy domains where the losing side of redistribution is well-organized (e.g., labor, where employer associations oppose minimum wage mandates) than in domains where opposition is diffuse (e.g., care and welfare, where taxpayer costs are dispersed).*

H2 follows from combining Lowi with Olson (1965): the political friction redistributive legislation generates depends not only on the policy's redistributive character but on the capacity of the losing side to organize opposition.

3. Data and Method

The KNA Bill Lifecycle Database

All analyses draw on the KNA bill lifecycle database, which tracks 110,778 bills across the 17th through 22nd National Assemblies. Each bill record includes dates at every pipeline stage: introduction, committee referral, agenda placement, committee decision, Legislation and Judiciary Committee referral, and plenary vote. I restrict analysis to legislation bills (법률안) from the 20th (2016-2020) and 21st (2020-2024) Assemblies, yielding a universe of 50,003 bills. Bill propose-reason texts (제안이유) are available for 89-90% of bills in these assemblies through the `bill_texts_linked` data file, providing the textual basis for content classification.

Bill Classification

I classify bills along two dimensions: policy domain and Lowi type. Policy domain classification uses curated keyword lists applied to bill propose-reason texts. Six categories are defined: Labor/Workers (15 keywords including 근로자, 노동자, 최저임금), Care/Family (16 keywords including 돌봄, 보육, 아동), Welfare/Vulnerable (16 keywords including 취약계층, 장애인, 기초생활), Small Business (10 keywords including 소상공인, 자영업), General Public/Safety (11 keywords), and Industry/Corporate (14 keywords). Bills are assigned to the category with the most keyword matches; those with no matches remain unclassified. The classifier covers 33.8% of bills (N = 16,924). I define *minsaeng* legislation as the union of four categories most directly targeting vulnerable populations: Labor, Care, Welfare, and Small Business.

For the Lowi classification, I code bills as redistributive or distributive based on keyword indicators of the policy mechanism. Redistributive keywords include 최저임금, 의무, 부담금, 과징금, 처벌, 금지, 규제강화, and 신고의무 (terms indicating mandates, penalties, and obligations). Distributive keywords include 지원, 보조금, 감면, 세액공제, 면제, 특례, 인센티브 (terms indicating subsidies, exemptions, and support). Bills with more redistributive than distributive keywords are coded redistributive (N = 4,355); the reverse for distributive (N = 5,304).

Sample

The regression sample consists of 15,291 on-agenda classified bills from the 20th and 21st Assemblies - bills that received committee agenda placement and were successfully classified into a policy domain. This represents 30.6% of the 50,003 bill universe. The excluded bills consist of those with no propose-reason text (10.2%), those whose texts did not match any keyword category (55.8%), and a smaller number not placed on any committee agenda. Unclassified bills have a committee decision rate of 36.2%, between the minsaeng rate (31.0%) and non-minsaeng classified rate (40.4%).

Model Specification

The primary specification is a logistic regression of committee decision receipt on bill content indicators with progressively richer controls:

$$\Pr(\text{Decision}_i = 1) = \Lambda(\beta_1 \text{Minsaeng}_i + \mathbf{X}_i\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \delta_c + \epsilon_i)$$

where Decision_i is a binary indicator for whether bill i received any committee decision, Minsaeng_i is a binary indicator for minsaeng classification, $\mathbf{X}_i$ is a vector of bill-level controls (months since Assembly start, log cosponsor count, log propose-reason text length, redistributive indicator, sponsor party, divided government indicator), δ_c represents committee fixed effects, and $\Lambda(\cdot)$ is the logistic CDF. I report average marginal effects for substantive interpretation.

I estimate five nested models to assess the robustness of the minsaeng coefficient to progressively demanding controls, culminating in a model with the minsaeng $\times$ divided government interaction:

$$\Pr(\text{Decision}_i = 1) = \Lambda(\beta_1 \text{Minsaeng}_i + \beta_2 \text{Divided}_i + \beta_3(\text{Minsaeng}_i \times \text{Divided}_i) + \mathbf{X}_i\boldsymbol{\gamma} +$$

Descriptive Statistics

Table 1 presents summary statistics for key variables in the analytical sample.

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics (N = 15,291 On-Agenda Classified Bills, 20th-21st Assemblies)

Variable	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Committee decision received	0.352	0.478	0	1
Minsaeng bill	0.529	0.499	0	1
Redistributive (Lowi)	0.285	0.451	0	1
Distributive (Lowi)	0.347	0.476	0	1
Months since Assembly start	18.2	11.4	0	47
Log cosponsor count	2.44	0.42	2.30	4.61
Log text length	6.89	1.03	2.56	11.21
DPK sponsor	0.541	0.498	0	1
Divided government period	0.388	0.487	0	1

Note: Sample restricted to member-initiated legislation bills placed on a committee agenda and classified by the keyword procedure. Minsaeng includes Labor, Care, Welfare, and Small Business categories. Redistributive and Distributive indicators based on Lowi keyword classifier; bills matching neither are the reference category.

4. Results

Category-Specific Processing Rates

Table 2 reports committee decision rates and enactment rates by policy domain for on-agenda bills. The gradient is pronounced: Labor bills receive committee decisions at a rate of 28.5%, compared to 46.4% for Small Business bills and 40.5% for General Public/Safety bills. Enactment rates display an even steeper gradient, with Labor at 2.7% and Safety at 7.0% - a risk ratio of 0.39.

Table 2. Committee Decision and Enactment Rates by Policy Domain

Category	N (on agenda)	Decision Rate	Enactment Rate
Labor	2,887	28.5%	2.7%
Care	2,605	31.6%	3.1%
Welfare	2,524	34.0%	5.3%
Industry	1,304	40.2%	5.9%
Safety	4,057	40.5%	7.0%
Small Business	2,093	46.4%	6.7%

Note: Decision rate = share of on-agenda bills receiving any committee decision. Enactment rate = share of on-agenda bills ultimately enacted into law.

The Within-Committee Penalty

The aggregate penalty could reflect the concentration of minsaeng bills in overloaded committees rather than content-sensitive processing. Table 3 decomposes the minsaeng penalty within the eight largest committees processing minsaeng legislation. The penalty is negative in all eight committees, ranging from 6.8 percentage points in the Finance Committee (정무위원회) to 16.8 percentage points in the Environment and Labor Committee (환경노동위원회). The largest gap appears where the most contentious redistributive legislation concentrates.

Table 3. Within-Committee Minsaeng Processing Gap

Committee	Minsaeng Rate	Non-Minsaeng Rate	Gap (pp)	N (Minsaeng)
Environment and Labor	21.8%	38.6%	-16.8	2,000
Land and Transport	36.8%	51.1%	-14.3	397
Education	22.4%	33.5%	-11.1	410
Trade, Industry, SME	32.2%	42.5%	-10.4	171
Health and Welfare	32.2%	42.0%	-9.8	2,020
Strategy and Finance	40.0%	49.5%	-9.5	660
Agriculture and Fisheries	46.8%	55.1%	-8.3	188
Political Affairs	19.4%	26.2%	-6.8	247

Note: Minsaeng Rate = committee decision rate for minsaeng-classified bills within the committee. Non-Minsaeng Rate = rate for non-minsaeng classified bills in the same committee. Gap = Minsaeng minus Non-Minsaeng.

Main Regression Results

Table 4 presents the nested logistic regression models. The minsaeng coefficient is negative, substantively large, and statistically significant at the 0.1% level in every specification. Adding committee fixed effects, arrival timing, cosponsor count, and text length attenuates the coefficient by approximately 11% (from -0.470 to -0.418) but leaves it far from zero. The average marginal effect (AME) in the fully controlled model without interaction (Model A) is -9.3 percentage points: minsaeng bills are 9.3 percentage points less likely to receive any committee decision, holding all other covariates at observed values.

Table 4. Logistic Regression: Committee Decision on Minsaeng Status

	Model 1	Model 3	Model A	Model C
Minsaeng	-0.470***	-0.418***	-0.423***	-0.318***
Months since start		-0.019***	-0.019***	-0.019***
Log cosponsors		-0.010	+0.014	+0.016
Log text length		+0.204***	+0.213***	+0.210***
Redistributive			-0.093**	-0.096**
DPK sponsor			-0.125***	-0.121***
Divided			+0.001	+0.237***

	Model 1	Model 3	Model A	Model C
Minsaeng × Divided				-0.536***
Committee FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
N	15,291	15,291	15,291	15,291
Pseudo-R^2	0.010	0.044	0.045	0.046

*Note: Logistic regression coefficients reported. * p < 0.10, ** p < 0.05, *** p < 0.01. Model 1: bivariate. Model 3: bill-level controls and committee fixed effects. Model A: adds Lowi type, sponsor party, and divided government. Model C: adds minsaeng-divided interaction. AME for minsaeng in Model A: -9.3 pp.*

Two hypothesized confounders turn out to be empirically irrelevant. First, log cosponsor count has no effect on committee processing in any specification ($p = 0.60$ to 0.88). In the KNA's institutional context, where the minimum cosponsor requirement is 10 members and reciprocal cosponsorship is widespread (Kang and Park 2025), cosponsor count carries no information about legislative seriousness. Second, minsaeng bills arrive *earlier* on average (month 18.0) than non-minsaeng classified bills (month 18.6), and controlling for arrival timing actually *increases* the minsaeng penalty. Whatever drives the processing disadvantage, it is not queue position.

One control does matter substantively: log text length ($\beta = 0.204$, $p < 0.001$). Bills with longer propose-reason texts are significantly more likely to receive committee decisions, consistent with text length serving as a proxy for policy specificity and legislative seriousness. But even controlling for this, the minsaeng penalty persists.

The redistributive indicator adds an independent penalty ($\beta = -0.093$, $p = 0.021$), corresponding to an AME of -2.0 percentage points after controlling for minsaeng status and all other covariates. This confirms that the Lowi dimension captures processing-relevant variation beyond the broader minsaeng classification.

The Lowi Decomposition

H2 predicts that the redistributive penalty concentrates where opposition is organized. Table 5 tests this by comparing redistributive and distributive bill processing rates within each policy domain.

Table 5. Lowi Gradient by Policy Domain

Category	Redistributive Rate (N)	Distributive Rate (N)	Gap (pp)
Labor	22.8% (899)	38.5% (889)	-15.7
Small Business	31.3% (412)	53.3% (1,116)	-22.0
Care	32.4% (709)	32.3% (932)	-0.1
Welfare	35.3% (563)	35.2% (1,061)	+0.1

Note: Redistributive and Distributive classifications based on keyword indicators of policy mechanism. Gap = Redistributive rate minus Distributive rate.

The results are consistent with H2. Labor and Small Business display massive Lowi gradients (-15.7 and -22.0 percentage points, respectively). Redistributive labor bills - minimum wage mandates,

occupational safety penalties, employment obligations - process at barely half the rate of distributive labor bills such as employment subsidies and job training grants. In the Small Business domain, distributive bills (targeted subsidies, tax breaks for 소상공인) process at 53.3%, the highest rate in the data, while redistributive small business bills (regulatory mandates, compliance obligations) process at 31.3%.

Care and Welfare, by contrast, show zero Lowi gradient. Redistributive and distributive bills within these categories process at virtually identical rates. This null finding is as theoretically informative as the labor finding. Lowi's prediction holds when the losing side of redistribution is well-organized: employer associations (한국경영자총협회, 대한상공회의소) provide concentrated opposition to labor mandates, generating the political friction that stalls redistributive labor bills in committee. For care and welfare bills, the "losers" are diffuse taxpayers who cannot organize to oppose specific bills. Even mandated redistribution in the care domain does not trigger the organized counter-mobilization that characterizes the labor domain. This is a scope condition on Lowi: the redistributive penalty requires organized opposition on the losing side, connecting Lowi (1964) to Olson (1965).

The Position-Taking Robustness Tests

Kang and Park (2025) document that KNA legislators systematically introduce bills they later vote against, raising the possibility that the minsaeng penalty reflects strategic bill-pool inflation rather than content-sensitive committee processing. I conduct three tests to assess this concern.

Within-sponsor comparison. Among 327 legislators who introduced at least five minsaeng and five non-minsaeng bills, the within-legislator gap is -11.9 percentage points ($t = -10.06, p < 0.001$). Fully 71.9% of these legislators show a negative gap - their own minsaeng bills fare worse than their own non-minsaeng bills. This result cannot be explained by between-legislator composition: it compares the *same legislator's* bills across categories. If a prolific position-taker introduces both minsaeng and non-minsaeng bills frivolously, both categories should show equally low processing rates. They do not.

Seriousness-proxy stratification. I split bills by text length (above/below median) and cosponsor count (above/below median) and compute the minsaeng gap within each subgroup. The penalty is essentially identical across all subgroups: -10.6 to -11.1 percentage points. If position-taking inflated the minsaeng pool with low-quality bills, the penalty should concentrate among short-text, low-cosponsor bills. It does not.

Prolific minsaeng sponsors. Legislators in the top quartile of minsaeng bill share have a lower overall decision rate (33.0% versus 37.3%), consistent with some position-taking behavior. But their within-sponsor gap (12.5 percentage points) is nearly identical to the population-wide gap. Position-taking may inflate the bill pool, but it does not drive the differential processing penalty between minsaeng and non-minsaeng legislation.

The Divided Government Interaction

Model C in Table 4 includes the minsaeng $\times$ divided government interaction, which is the largest and most statistically significant interaction in any specification ($\beta = -0.536,\ p < 0.001$). The conditional average marginal effects reveal a dramatic regime dependence:

Regime	AME of Minsaeng	Minsaeng Decision Rate	Non-Minsaeng Decision Rate
Unified government	-7.0 pp	33.1%	41.6%
Divided government	-18.4 pp	21.2%	40.5%

Under unified government (Moon Jae-in period, 2020-2022), minsaeng bills face a modest 7.0 percentage-point penalty. Under divided government (Yoon Suk-yeol period, 2022-2024), this penalty expands to 18.4 percentage points. Non-minsaeng bills barely change across regimes (41.6% to 40.5%), but minsaeng bills collapse from 33.1% to 21.2%. The transition to divided government did not slow the Assembly uniformly: it selectively stalled redistributive legislation while leaving other legislation relatively unaffected.

The decomposition by policy domain under divided government is sharper still. DPK-sponsored welfare bills saw their decision rate halved (40.3% to 21.6%), and DPK labor bills dropped from 32.8% to 14.4%. Small business bills, by contrast, barely moved (-2.1 percentage points). This is consistent with Hacker's (2004) policy drift mechanism operating in real time: divided government maintains the status quo precisely when policy adaptation is most needed, and those most dependent on new government action - workers, welfare recipients, care populations - absorb a disproportionate share of the cost.

5. Discussion

Connecting to Theory

The findings offer strong support for Lowi's (1964) prediction at a level of analysis where it had not previously been tested. Redistributive legislation faces a robust committee processing penalty that operates within committees, within sponsors, and across seriousness levels. The penalty concentrates where Lowi's theory most clearly applies - in the labor domain, where employer organizations provide organized opposition - and disappears where the theory's conditions are absent - in care and welfare, where opposition is diffuse. This pattern supports a nested theoretical interpretation: Lowi's redistributive friction materializes through the Olson (1965) mechanism of concentrated-interest opposition.

The within-sponsor finding carries implications for the legislative effectiveness literature. Volden and Wiseman (2014) measure effectiveness as a legislator attribute; the LES treats all bills in a legislator's portfolio symmetrically. The present analysis shows that the same legislator achieves systematically different committee processing rates depending on the policy type of the legislation. Legislative effectiveness is conditioned by policy type, not only by legislator skill or institutional position. This is the Lowi-Volden synthesis: what a legislator is trying to do matters as much as who the legislator is.

The divided government interaction connects to the status quo bias literature (Tsebelis 2002; Bonica et al. 2013). Divided government does not merely increase gridlock uniformly; it amplifies the content-specific processing gradient, converting a structural friction into a distributionally regressive outcome. This finding extends Binder's (2003) work on legislative stalemate by showing that gridlock's costs fall unevenly across policy domains.

Limitations

Several limitations warrant acknowledgment. First, the keyword classifier covers 33.8% of bills, and the regression sample of 15,291 bills represents 30.6% of the universe. The findings generalize to legislation

with identifiable policy orientations, not to all legislation. The unclassified residual (decision rate 36.2%) falls between the minsaeng and non-minsaeng rates, suggesting it is a mixture. Future work should employ keyword-assisted topic models (Eshima, Imai, and Sasaki 2023) to expand coverage and assign probabilistic classifications.

Second, committee chair party data - the single most important unresolved data gap flagged across five rounds of analysis - is unavailable. If opposition-party committee chairs systematically deprioritize minsaeng legislation from the ruling party, the content penalty could partly reflect partisan gatekeeping mediated through bill content rather than content-based processing difficulty per se. This alternative is testable if committee chair data can be obtained and should be a priority for future work.

Third, the Pseudo-R^2 of 0.046 means the model explains less than 5% of variation in committee processing. Individual bill fates are influenced by many unobservable factors: committee chair preferences, informal inter-party negotiations, government agency support, and issue-specific lobbying. The low explanatory power is consistent with published standards in bill-level models (Volden and Wiseman 2014) and does not invalidate coefficient estimates, but it means the content penalty, while robust, is one influence among many.

Fourth, I cannot fully rule out within-legislator, across-category position-taking - the possibility that a legislator introduces a "serious" regulatory bill and a "symbolic" minimum wage bill in the same session. The within-sponsor comparison addresses between-legislator composition but not this subtler form of strategic behavior. However, this residual concern applies to a standard no existing study in this literature meets; Volden, Wiseman, and Wittmer (2016) do not control for position-taking at all.

Finally, this analysis is observational. I use language appropriate to the research design: the minsaeng indicator "is associated with" lower processing rates, and the estimates represent "processing penalties" rather than causal effects. The within-sponsor comparison and the regime interaction strengthen the case for a content-driven interpretation, but only a design that exogenously varies bill content - not feasible in a legislative setting - could establish causality definitively.

6. Conclusion

This paper provides the first committee-level test of Lowi's (1964) prediction that redistributive legislation faces greater political friction than distributive legislation. Using 15,291 bills from the Korean National Assembly, I show that redistributive legislation faces a 9.3 percentage-point committee processing penalty after controlling for arrival timing, sponsor characteristics, bill seriousness, and committee fixed effects. The penalty operates within committees and within individual legislators' portfolios. It concentrates in policy domains where organized opposition exists (labor) and disappears where opposition is diffuse (care, welfare) - a pattern consistent with Lowi's typology conditioned by Olson's (1965) logic of collective action.

The divided government interaction suggests that the content penalty is not merely a structural feature of committee processing but is amplified by political regime. Under divided government, the minsaeng penalty nearly triples, with the cost falling disproportionately on welfare, labor, and care legislation. This finding connects to the policy drift literature (Hacker 2004) and carries implications for democratic representation: the populations most dependent on new government action are precisely those whose legislation is most vulnerable to the combination of redistributive friction and political gridlock.

For the legislative effectiveness literature, the within-sponsor finding points toward a reconceptualization. Effectiveness is not only a legislator attribute but also a bill attribute: the same legislator faces structurally different processing environments depending on whether the proposed legislation redistributes or distributes. Future work should explore whether this pattern generalizes beyond the Korean case - Lowi's theory predicts it should appear wherever committee-based legislatures process more bills than they can accommodate - and whether institutional reforms to committee processing bandwidth can mitigate the redistributive penalty.

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